

Must-Know Grammar Rules

The only punctuation and grammar laws the Digital SAT Reading & Writing section actually tests.

The Punctuation Laws

Rule	How it works
Period (.) & Semicolon (;)	Grammatically identical on the SAT — both join two complete, independent sentences. Trick: if two choices differ only by . vs ; , eliminate both .
Colon (:)	Introduces a list, explanation, or quote. Whatever comes before the colon must be a complete sentence.
Comma + FANBOYS	To join two complete sentences with a comma you need a FANBOYS conjunction (For, And, Nor, But, Or, Yet, So). Comma alone = comma splice (wrong).
Dashes (— —)	Work like commas or parentheses for setting off extra info. They must come in pairs unless one ends the sentence.
No punctuation	Often the right answer. If the sentence already flows and is grammatical, don't add anything.

Grammar & Agreement

Concept	What to check
Subject-verb agreement	Match the verb to the true subject — ignore prepositional phrases in between. “Each / every / neither” are singular.
Pronoun agreement	A pronoun must match its noun in number. With “neither/nor,” the pronoun agrees with the nearest noun.
Verb tense	Keep tense consistent with the surrounding sentences unless the timeline clearly shifts.
Modifiers	The word right after an opening modifier must be the thing being described (avoid dangles).
Apostrophes	its = possessive, it's = it is. Plural noun → s' ; singular → 's.
Parallel structure	Items in a list or comparison must share the same grammatical form.

Transitions & Trap Answers

Watch for	Meaning / Move
Add: also, furthermore, moreover	Continue the same idea.

Contrast: however, but, yet, although	Flip the direction of the idea.
Cause: therefore, thus, as a result	Result follows from the prior sentence.
Extreme language (always, never, prove)	Usually a trap. Right answers are moderate.
True but irrelevant	Real-world true $\neq$ supported by the passage.